KIN 7518 SOCIAL ISSUES IN SPORT · LOUISIANA STATE UNIVERSITY · APRIL 2026

Sport Meets Politics: Trump's *Break 50* Appearance & Parasocial Politicization

~58,000 comments across YouTube, Instagram & X/Twitter

Group PKB Simon Koehne · Nicolas Porras · Samantha Bello

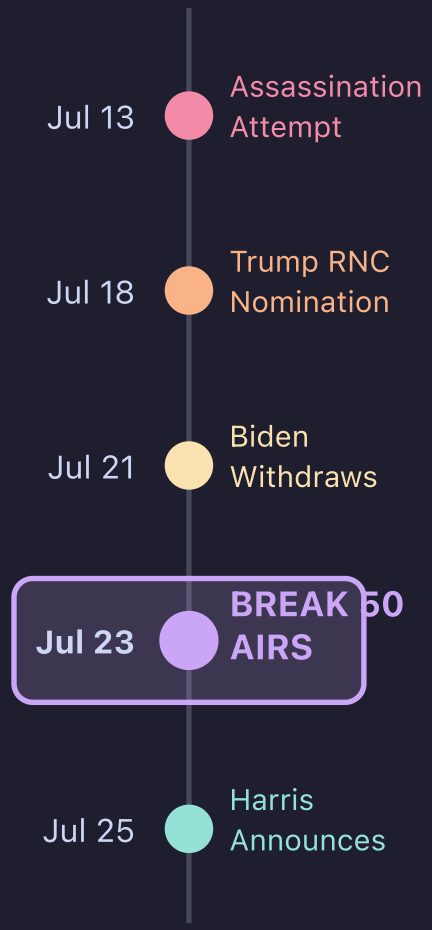
The Social Issue: Parasocial Politicization in Sport

The Problem: Sport-entertainment audiences who never sought political content get drawn into partisan discourse through their parasocial bond with a sport personality.

The Context: On **July 23–24, 2024**, Trump appeared on Bryson DeChambeau's golf YouTube series *Break 50* — a sport-entertainment format suddenly made into a high-profile political media event.

Research Question: How does sport-politics crossover content generate cross-platform political discourse — and *who* drives its amplification?

Theory: *parasocial politicization* (Larkin, 2025) · political celebrity (Street, 2018) · digital nationalism (Su et al., 2025)



Research Questions

RQ1 — Temporal Dynamics of Cross-Platform Discourse

How does the volume and emotional intensity of audience discourse about Trump's *Break 50* appearance shift over time across YouTube, Instagram, and X/Twitter — and can spikes in engagement activity be linked to specific political events surrounding the episode's release?

RQ2 — Geographic & User-Level Amplification on X/Twitter

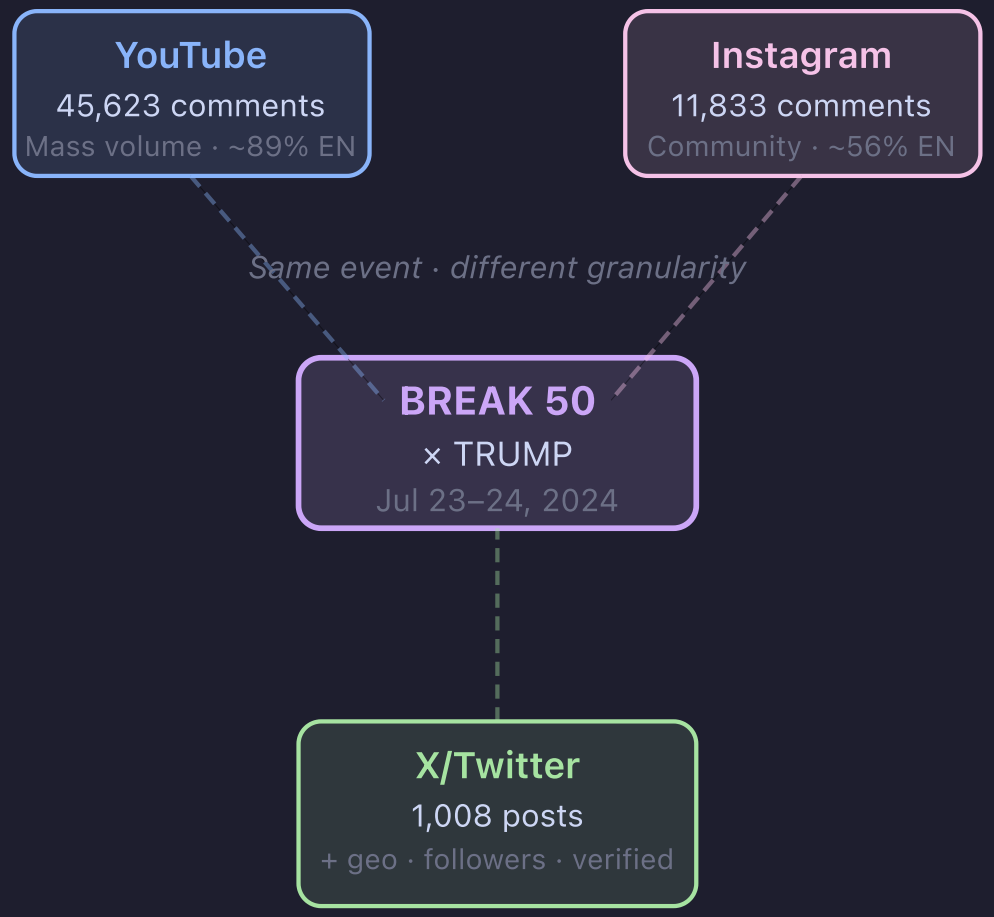
On X/Twitter, do a commenter's geographic location and account influence level (follower count and verification status) predict the degree to which they amplify partisan discourse about Trump's *Break 50* appearance?

Data & Scope

Three platforms, one originating event — July 23–24, 2024

YouTube	Text, likes, replies, timestamp	45,623
Instagram	Text, likes, replies, timestamp	11,833
X/Twitter	+ followers, geo location, verification, views	1,008

58,464 total records ~48,000 English (VADER)



Analytical Strategy

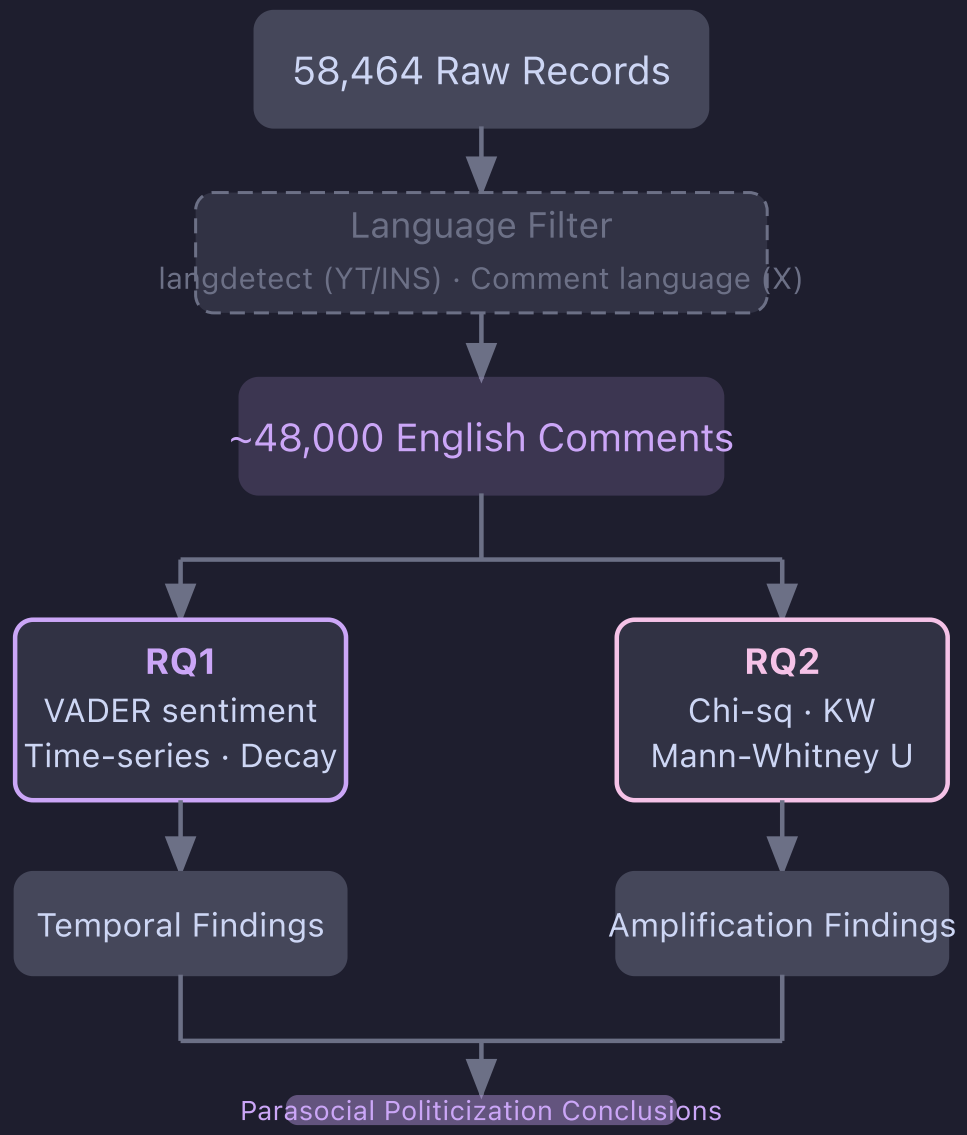
Two research questions · five methods

RQ1 — Temporal Dynamics (All platforms)

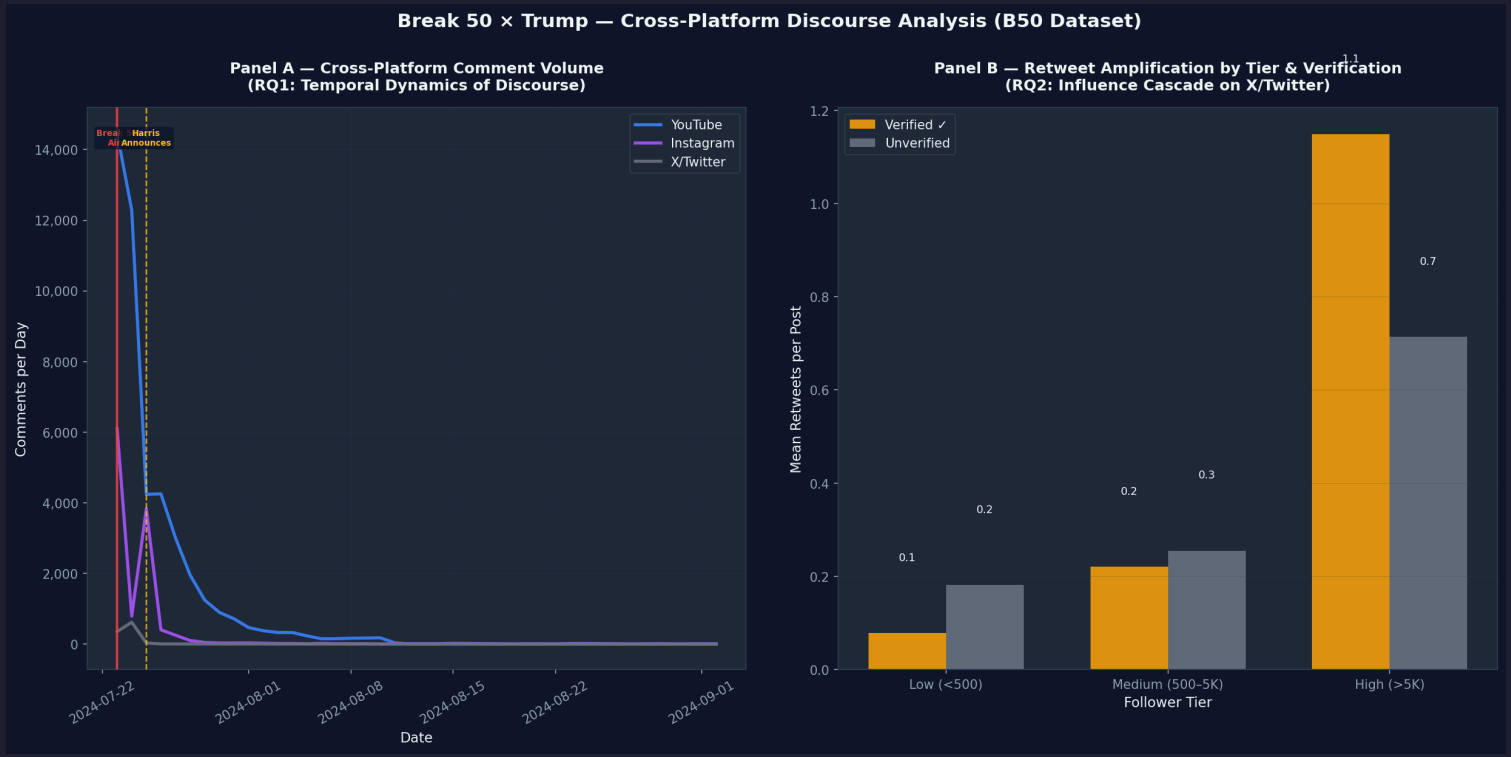
- Time-series volume analysis & Pearson r
- VADER sentiment (~48K English comments)
- Engagement decay regression (YT vs. INS)

RQ2 — Geographic & Influence Amplification (X only)

- Chi-square goodness-of-fit (geographic lean)
- Chi-square independence (partisan × geo)
- Kruskal-Wallis + Dunn's (follower tiers)
- Mann-Whitney U (verification status)



Finding 1 — Event-Driven Volume Spikes



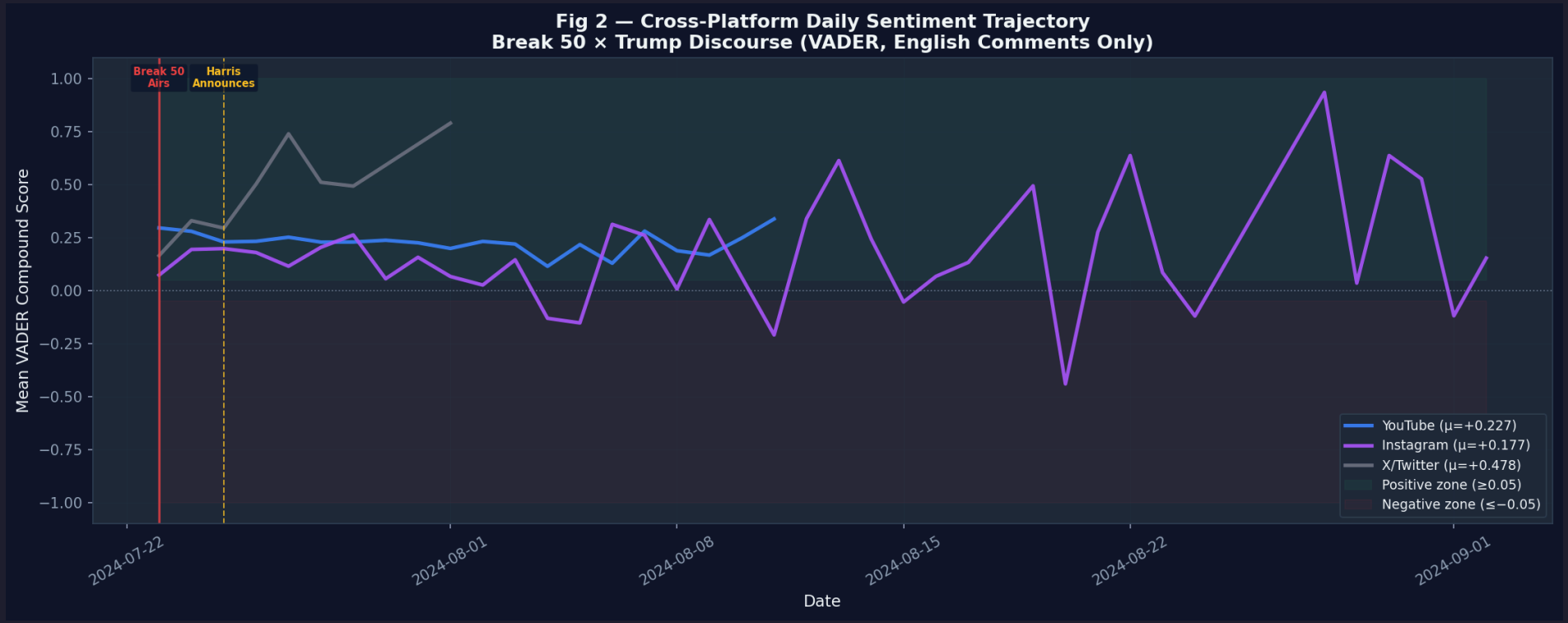
r = 0.777
YouTube
$p < 0.001$ ✓

r = 0.611
Instagram
$p < 0.001$ ✓

r = 0.544
X/Twitter
$p = 0.0003$ ✓

Interpretation: Discourse was *event-driven and punctuated* — not organically decaying. YouTube's stronger correlation reflects its larger, politically reactive audience base.

Finding 2 — An Unexpected Sentiment Result

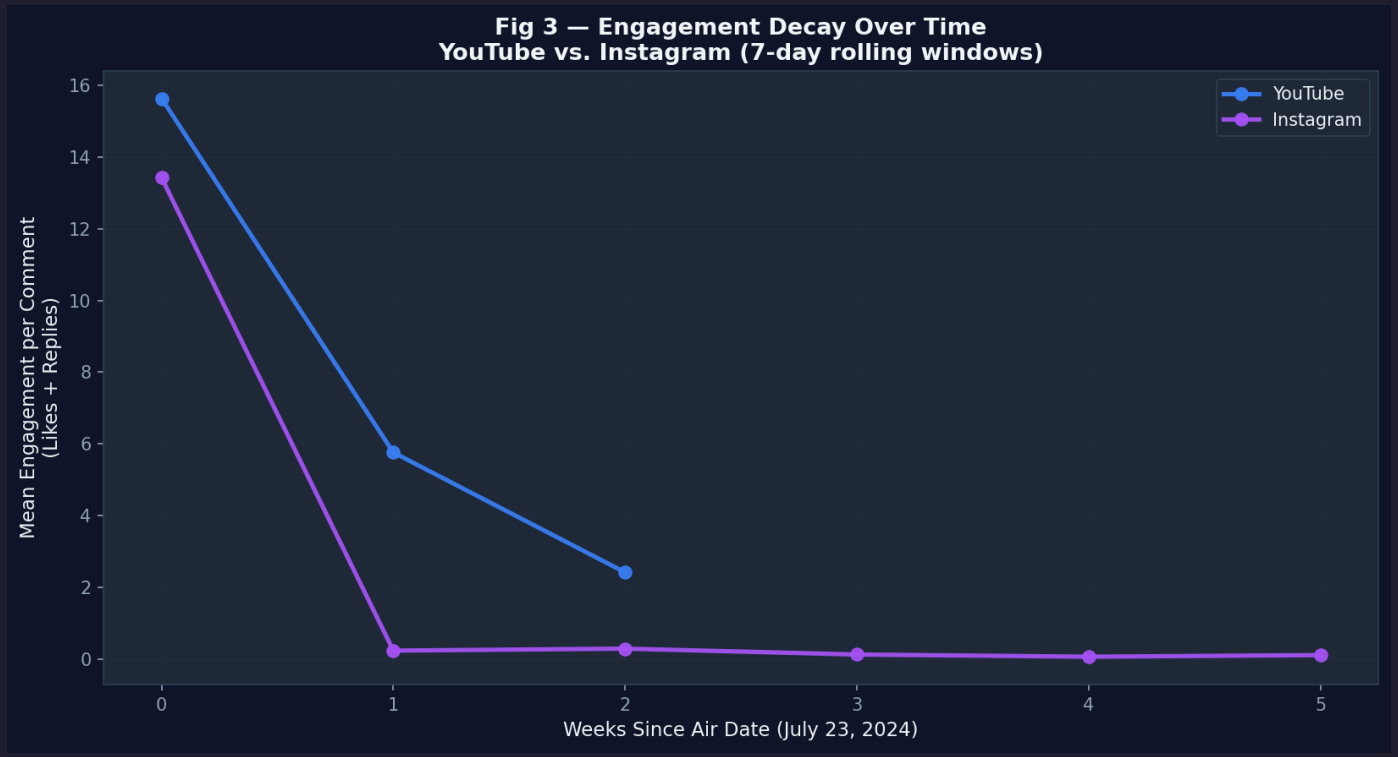


Expected: Net *negative* sentiment — political intrusion is contentious.

Reality: All platforms returned *net positive* VADER scores.

+0.227	+0.177	+0.478
YouTube	Instagram	X/Twitter

Finding 3 — Engagement Decay: YouTube vs. Instagram

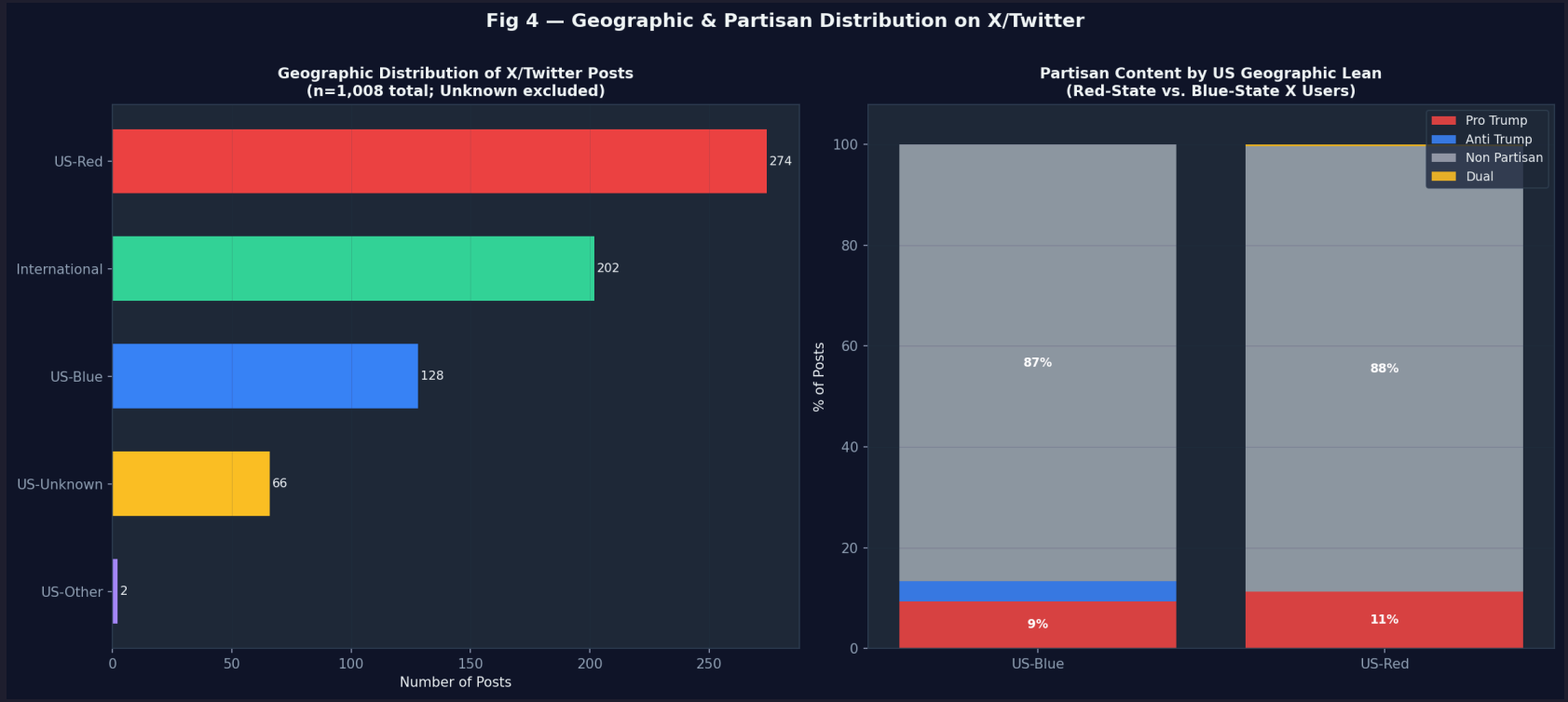


−1.43
per day (YouTube)
p = 0.009 ✓

−0.86
per day (Instagram)
p = 0.198 — n.s.

YouTube decays significantly; Instagram shows more sustained community engagement. Weekly decay *rates* not statistically distinguishable (Mann-Whitney U = 16.0, p = 0.095).

Finding 4 — Geographic Partisan Skew on X

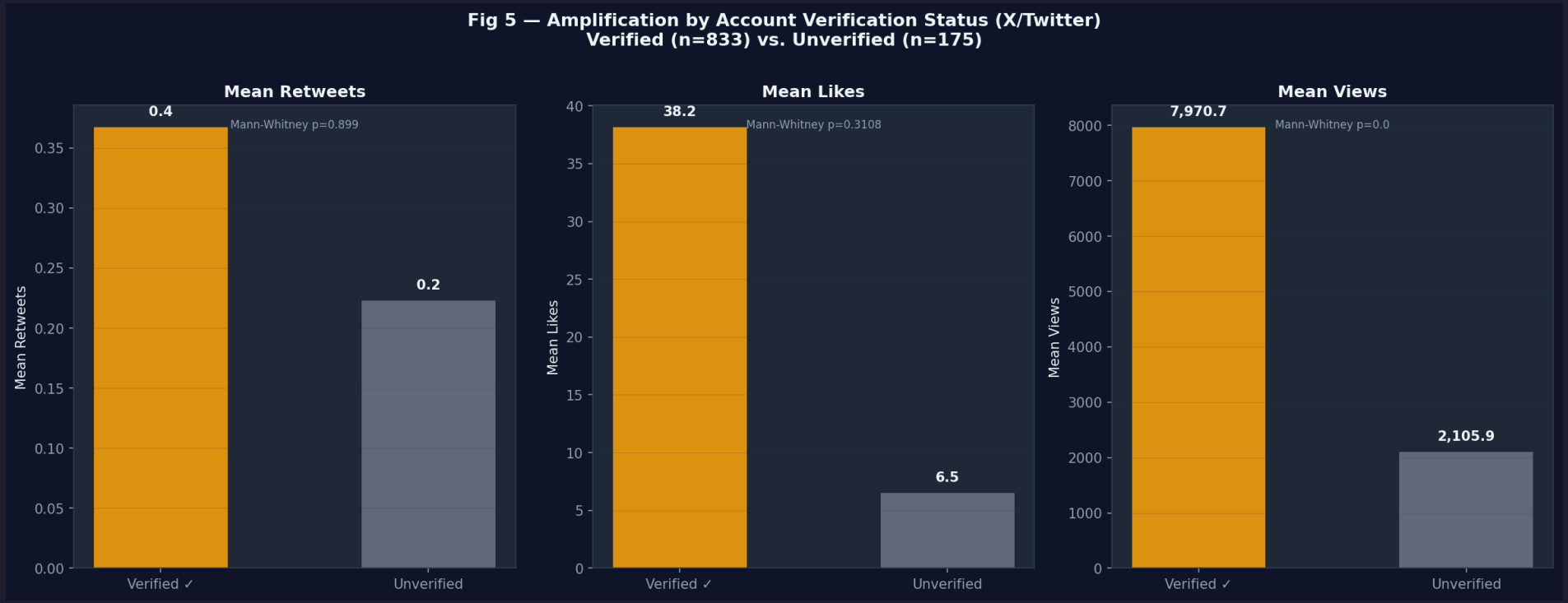


274
Red-State Users (27.2%)

128
Blue-State Users (12.7%)

$\chi^2 = 28.13$, $p < 0.001$ — X audience skews significantly Red-state, deviating from the expected 55/45 split. Partisan content difference not significant ($p = 0.066$) — both groups post ~87% non-partisan sport content.

Finding 5 — The Influence Cascade



Low
<500 followers
1,811 views · 5 likes

Medium
500–5K followers
6,467 views · 23 likes

High
>5K followers
19,465 views · 116 likes

10× retweets **23× likes** **11× views**

Verification: Verified accounts reach **3.8× more viewers** ($p < 0.001$) — a reach multiplier, not an engagement trigger.

Interpretation & Implications

THE "SO WHAT?"

Parasocial Politicization Works
Sport audiences who came for golf were politically activated — and volume stayed high, sustained by external political events, not just the episode itself.

Amplification Is Structural, Not Democratic
Political discourse in sport spaces on X is driven by elite, high-follower accounts — a top-down influence cascade, not organic fan spread.

Geographic Partisan Concentration
The *Break 50* episode activated a disproportionately Red-state X audience, consistent with digital nationalism and partisan network clustering.

FOR SPORT MANAGERS & MEDIA PRODUCERS

Athlete-political partnerships don't have one-time consequences — they embed sport personalities in ongoing political narratives that extend well past the content window.

Platform choice matters — YouTube's stronger event-volume correlation suggests mass-audience platforms amplify political crossover more than community platforms like Instagram.

Key limitations: 33% missing X location data; VADER sarcasm sensitivity; small X sample; geographic findings exploratory only. Full limitations →

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Thank You

Questions?